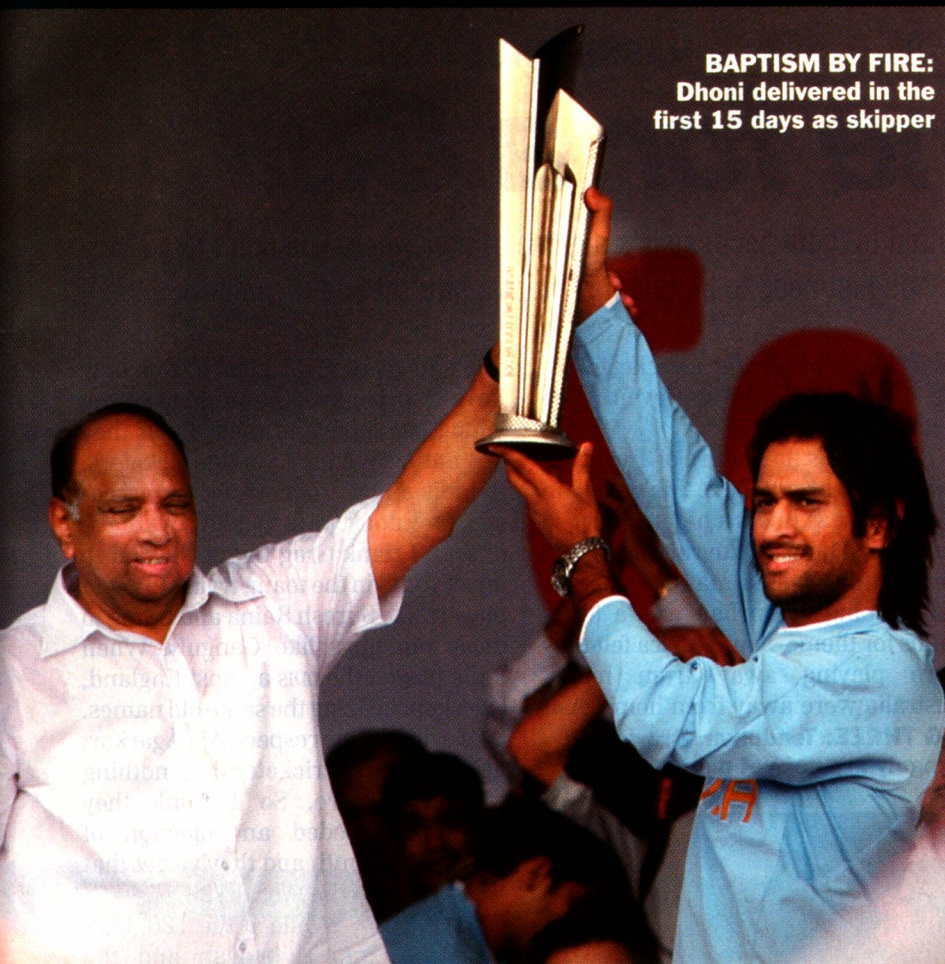




**BAPTISM BY FIRE:**  
Dhoni delivered in the  
first 15 days as skipper

SHRIYA PATIL

his boldness with calculation, Rohit Sharma his quality with unceasing labour, Sreesanth his gifts with temperance? Can Irfan, Harbhajan and Sehwag get their groove back entirely?

What they have done together is to give Indian cricket its optimism again, its sense of possibility. The image of the T20 fleet feet will translate into a rumble for change, which can only be healthy. When India's victory was sealed, several leading lights of BCCI were there, jetting in with Vijay Mallya and Shah Rukh Khan, some throwing money at the team in grand, feudal gestures. The cricketers laughed it off, too euphoric to derive anything but mirth from it. But less than 12 hours later, they learnt that between seven ODIs vs Australia and a five-match ODI series vs Pakistan, the BCCI was planning to squeeze in a Challenger series too.

As the sun went down over Wanderers Stadium and the men in blue entangled in flags, collapsed on the turf and on each other, one man watched them on TV in Mumbai with calm contentment. Sachin Tendulkar seemed to pick up a vibe. "The team is in safe hands," he said. ■

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